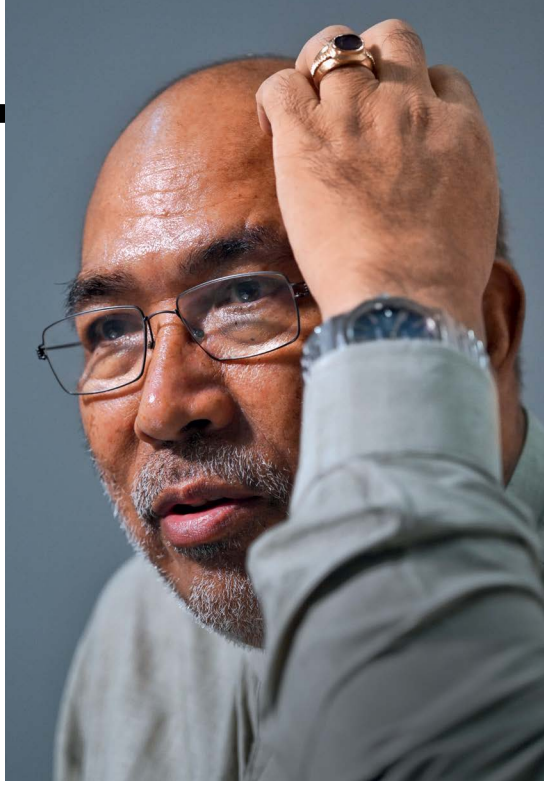
INTERVIEW N. BIREN SINGH

'I AM AGAINST ILLEGAL IMMIGRANTS, NOT THE KUKIS'



Manipur Chief Minister N. BIREN SINGH stands accused of failing to control the horrific violence even after nearly three months. In an exclusive interview with Executive Editor KAUSHIK DEKA, he claims the ethnic clashes are fuelled by illegal immigrants and druglords. Excerpts:

Q. Why is Manipur still burning?

I did not create this environment. There has been a constant attempt to destabilise our government. Illegal immigrants are trying to create unrest in the state, a situation I had predicted 10 years ago. Poppy cultivation has been growing, and there has been a rise in drug trafficking too. I tried to tackle these issues within the boundaries of constitutional provisions. But suddenly the violence erupted. This is the work of those resentful of Manipur's rapid development in recent years.

Q. Why have you not been able to control it for three months?

Two brothers are fighting, and the government is like a father mediating between them. We have to be patient, must move forward carefully without hurting the interests of either community. Peace is returning gradually.

Q. Will you resign?

I have been elected to the assembly by the 34 tribes of Manipur. I was made chief minister by the central leadership of the BJP. If the Centre wants me to resign, I will. However, I am not thinking about it at this

pegged their number at 2,480, this hypernarrative on illegal immigrants, fed by Biren himself, has intensified Kuki insecurities. "The CM leaves no opportunity to brand Kukis as foreigners, drug traffickers and terrorists," says Ginza Vualzong, spokesperson, Indigenous Tribal Leaders Forum. "He cannot expect us to keep quiet and accept this continued humiliation."

More fuel was poured on that ethnic fire when the state unilaterally decided on March 10 this year to withdraw the Suspension of Operation (SoO) pact with two Kuki militant groups—the Kuki National Army (KNA) and the Zomi Revolutionary Army (ZRA)—alleging that they were instigating people against the government's anti-encroachment drive. This tripartite agreement between the Centre, the state and Kuki militants was inked in 2008. The understanding had enjoined both the security forces and insurgent groups to refrain from armed hostilities in the hope of laying the ground for a negotiated settlement. Manipur has some 32 Kuki insurgent groups, out of which 25, including KNA and ZRA, are under the SoO. These groups operate under two umbrella organisations—17 under the Kuki National Organisation (KNO) and eight under the United People Front (UPF)—and have been agitating for a separate Kuki homeland.

The Meiteis, on the other hand, allege that the central government and the armed forces, particularly the Assam Rifles, are soft on the Kuki militants, who are said to be actively participating in the current violence. Lending credence to this charge is a PIL that S.S. Haokip, chairman of the United Kuki Liberation Front (UKLF), one of the armed outfits under the SoO, filed in an NIA (National Investigation Agency) court on June 8. It included a 2019 letter Haokip had written to home minister Amit Shah, in which he claimed that the UKLF and the UPF, another Kuki group, had helped BJP candidates win in the 2017 assembly election, per an agreement with Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and former BJP in-charge of the Northeast, Ram Madhav. They had also helped the BJP in the 2019 general election, claimed the letter.

Indeed, the KNO and UPF had publicly extended support to BJP candidates in Kuki areas in the 2022 state polls. The revelation has embarrassed the state BJP unit as the Meiteis saw this as a betrayal. Though Sarma initially did not respond